

SUBHADRA

MAJHI TURNS **"FRIEND IN NEED'** FOR ALL

Promise of financial assistance directly to women has been a poll winner since Jayalalitha days. Many political parties have won elections on this plank. Most popular story is that of Shivraj Singh Chauhan, who during his long tenure as Chief Minister of Madhya Pradesh had earned the epithet "Mama" (maternal uncle) for his government's "Ladli Behna" scheme.

After forming government in Odisha with a sound majority, Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi also came up with such a scheme "Subhadra Yojana", named after the sister of Lord Jagannath. The scheme has apparently made Majhi a "Bhai" of the womenfolk of Odisha.

Subhadra Yojana is a women-centric welfare scheme launched on 17th September last year, coinciding with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's birthday. It aims to empower over one crore women across the state by providing direct financial assistance, thereby promoting economic independence and social upliftment of women.

It provides financial support to women aged between 21 and 60 years from economically weaker section. Eligible women receive a total of Rs 50,000 over five years, disbursed in annual installments of Rs 10,000. Each year, the amount is split into two installments of Rs 5,000, credited directly to the beneficiaries' Aadhaar-linked bank accounts on Raksha Bandhan and International Women's Day.



To ensure efficient delivery, the scheme leverages the JAM trinity (Jan Dhan-Aadhaar-Mobile) framework. Beneficiaries are provided with a "Subhadra Debit Card" to facilitate seamless transactions. Additionally, the top 100 beneficiaries in each gram panchayat and urban area with the highest digital transactions receive an additional Rs 500 incentive.

With a total budget allocation of Rs 55,825 crore for the period 2024-29, economists anticipate that the scheme will have a multiplier effect, potentially contributing Rs 2.5 lakh crore to Odisha's economy over the five years. Named after Devi Subhadra, it holds cultural significance also because of its association with 'Rakhi'.

SUCCESS STORIES

SUNANDA JANI

Another example of the Subhadra Yojana transforming the life of the rural women is Sunanda Jani of Digapahandi in Ganjam district. She lost her shopkeeper husband 12 years ago. She did take a small bank loan to revive the shop but repaying monthly instalments was a big challenge. With the Subhadra funds, she bought stock for the shop and palm leaves for craft-making. Slowly, things began to look up, and now she is in a position to provide her children better education.

MEENAKSHI BADHEI

A notable example of Subhadra Yojana's impact is the case of Meenakshi Badhei, a student and daughter of an auto driver, from Sevakapur in Rayagada block of Gajapati district. Facing financial challenges in pursuing higher education, Meenakshi benefited from the scheme, which helped her resume her studies and rekindled her dream of a stable job that will allow her to support her family, and walk towards a life of dignity and purpose.

DEEPTI SAHU

Similarly, a tribal woman of Sagarguda in Kundra block of Koraput district has turned Subhadra support into a steady business. 34-year-old Deepti Sahu's tailoring skills remained underutilised for years due to financial crunch. As she used the Subhadra funds to buy better fabric and stock up on festive clothing materials, her sales slowly picked up which helped her stand on her own feet.